

CHORUS: Retribution for evils. Changed gales of vengeance blow through the house. Once my king, mine, fell stricken in his bath. The stones and the rooftop shrieked with the cry that he uttered: "O wretched woman, my wife, why will you kill me who have returned to my dear fatherland after ten years?" In retribution, this unhappy woman of an adulterous marriage is brought to justice, she who took up an axe with sharpened blade and by her own hand killed her husband who had returned after many years to his home and its Cyclopean walls that reach to the sky. A poor, suffering husband, whatever evil wrong took hold of his unhappy wife. Like a lioness roaming the woods, who pastures in the mountains, she accomplished her deeds. (1147–1164) 160

CLYTEMNESTRA: (from inside the house): O my children, by the gods, do not kill your mother.

CHORUS: Do you hear her cry from within?

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, woe is me!

CHORUS: I pity her, overpowered and undone by her children. God metes out justice, sooner or later. You have suffered a terrible fate, but you, poor wretch, committed an unholy crime against your husband. But here they come out of the house, defiled with freshly shed blood of their mother, triumphal testimony of how they silenced her cries of anguish. No house is more lamentable than that of the family of Tantalus. (1168–1176) 170

Orestes and Electra appear, the bodies of both Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at their feet. After the horror of murdering their mother, all bravado is gone, and upon full realization of what they have done, they become craven with a remorse that is both sad and repellent. Electra must bear full responsibility for committing the crime along with Orestes; brother and sister have learned to their dismay and regret that the desire for retribution, even when ordained by the command of god, is far different emotionally and psychologically from the real trauma of actually killing their mother.

ORESTES: O Earth and Zeus, you who witness all that mortals do, behold these bloody, abominable murders, two corpses lying on the ground, struck down by my hand in recompense for my sufferings. (1177–1181)

ELECTRA: Our tears overflow, my brother, and I am the cause. In fiery rage I, poor wretch, came against this mother of mine, who bore me, her daughter.

CHORUS: Alas for misfortune, your misfortune. You, the mother who bore them, have suffered unforgettable misery and more at the hands of your children and you have paid justly for the murder of their father. (1185–1189)

ORESTES: O Phoebus, you prophesied a justice I could not foresee, but all too clear now is the misery that you have wrought. You have bestowed on me the fate of a murderer driven from this land of Hellas. To what other city will I go? What friend, what god-fearing human being will look upon the face of a man who has killed his mother? (1190–1197) 10

ELECTRA: Alas, woe is me! Where will I go? At what dance will I be accepted? What marriage will be in store for me? What husband will take me to his marriage bed?

CHORUS: Your thoughts have been changed back once again to considerations that are good. Now your thinking is holy; then it was not and you made your brother do a terrible thing, when he did not want to. (1201–1205)



Audio

ORESTES: Did you see how the poor woman opened her robe to show me her breast as I slaughtered her, alas for me, and I grabbed at her hair as her body that gave me birth sank to the floor? 20

CHORUS: I know full well the pain that you went through when you heard the piercing cry of your mother who bore you. (1210–1212)

ORESTES: This was the cry that she uttered as she touched my cheek with her hand: “My child, I beg you,” and then she clung to me so closely that my sword fell from my hand.

CHORUS: Poor woman! How did you dare to see with your own eyes your mother breathing out her life? (1218–1220)

ORESTES: I covered my eyes with my cloak as we began the sacrifice, plunging the sword into my mother’s flesh. 30

ELECTRA: I ordered you to do it as we took hold of the sword together.

CHORUS: You have done a most terrible deed.

ORESTES: Come, help me cover the limbs of our mother with her garments and close up her wounds. You gave birth to your own murderers.

ELECTRA: See how we cover you, whom we loved and we hated. (1230–1231)

The play ends with the appearance of the Dioscuri, and it is Castor who acts as the *deus ex machina*. He reaffirms religious and philosophical issues raised by Orestes himself as he hesitates in horror, while his sister is prodding him to join her in murdering their mother. To kill a mother is a terrible crime, with devastating ramifications, whether or not it is decreed by god.

CHORUS: Thus end great evils for this house. But look! Who are these two who arrive high above the house? Are they divine spirits or gods from the heavens? Mortals do not appear in this way. Why in the world do they come into the clear sight of humans? (1232–1237)

DIOSCURI (Castor speaks for the two of them): Listen, son of Agamemnon. We, Castor and Polydeuces, address you, we the twin sons of Zeus, brothers of your mother. We just now calmed a terrible storm at sea and come to Argos in time to witness here the slaughter of our sister and your mother. She received justice, but you did not act justly. And Phoebus, O Phoebus—but since he is my lord, I keep silent. Being wise, he did not prophesy to you wise things. Yet all this must be commended and now you have to do what Fate and Zeus have ordained for you. (1238–1248) 10

Castor goes on at some length to predict the future course of events, including the pursuit of Orestes by the Furies and his acquittal by the court of the Areopagus in Athens. Pylades is to marry Electra.

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Herodotus	<i>History of the Persian Wars</i> 1.67.1–1.68.6 (the bones of Orestes)
Seneca	<i>Agamemnon</i>

Notes

1. These tales are brilliantly discussed by Walter Burkert, *Homo Necans* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983), pp. 83–109, part of his chapter entitled "Werewolves around the Tripod Kettle."
2. The Greek phrase is obscure. Cassandra refers to the instrument of the murder, either a sword or an axe, one or the other of which appears in different poetic accounts and vase paintings of the murder.
3. The Areopagus was the court at Athens that heard homicide cases; its members were former archons, that is, state officials. The court had been a center of political controversy shortly before Aeschylus produced his play.
4. Apollo's argument that the child's begetter is the father and not the mother because the mother is only the nurse of the newly sown seed need not be interpreted as a manifestation of Greek misogyny, as Mary R. Lefkowitz so clearly perceives in *Women in Greek Myth* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986), pp. 122–123: "[Apollo] is acting as an advocate for a person accused of matricide; had Orestes been accused of killing his father to avenge his mother, Apollo might well have said what Aeschylus has the Erinyes say about the primacy of maternal blood ties. The role of the female in conception, of course, was not clearly understood; opinions varied about whether the female seed present in the menstrual fluid contributed to the appearance and character of the child. . . . But no Athenian audience would have

believed that Apollo's argument was conclusive. . . . In fact, the jury in Aeschylus' drama gives Apollo and the Erinyes equal votes, and it is only because Athena, who was born from her father Zeus without a mother, casts her vote for Apollo that Orestes is acquitted."

5. For comparative examples, see George Thomson, *Aeschylus and Athens*. 3d ed. (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1996), p. 449.
6. The child of Clytemnestra and Aegisthus was Erigone, the theme of a lost play by Sophocles and mentioned by the early cyclic poet Cinaethon.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

The Trojan Saga and the *Iliad*

A shudder in the loins engenders there
The broken wall, the burning roof and tower
And Agamemnon dead.

—W. B. YEATS, *Leda and the Swan*



LEDA, WIFE OF TYNDAREUS, king of Sparta, bore four children to Zeus, who visited her in the shape of a swan; the four were born from two eggs—from the one sprang **Polydeuces** and **Helen**, from the other **Castor** and **Clytemnestra**.

The Dioscuri

The legends of the Dioscuri (Sons of Zeus), Castor and Polydeuces (his Roman name is **Pollux**), are not part of the saga of the Trojan War. Castor was renowned as a tamer of horses, and Polydeuces was famous for his skill in boxing. Polydeuces was the immortal son of Zeus, whereas Castor was the mortal son of Tyndareus, who eventually shared in the immortality of his brother. They were perhaps originally mortal heroes, later worshiped as gods. According to Pindar, the Dioscuri quarreled with the two sons of Aphareus, **Idas** and **Lynceus**, over the division of some cattle that the four of them had taken in a raid. In the quarrel, Lynceus and Castor were killed, and Idas was destroyed by Zeus' thunderbolt. As Castor lay dying, Polydeuces prayed to Zeus that he might die with him. Zeus gave him the choice either of immortality for himself and death for Castor or of living with Castor but spending alternate days on Olympus and in Hades. Polydeuces chose the latter, and so the Dioscuri shared both immortality and death.¹

As gods, Castor and Polydeuces were especially connected with seafarers, to whom they appear as St. Elmo's fire.² They were particularly honored at Sparta, and in the early fifth century B.C. their cult spread to Rome.³ One of the most prominent buildings in the Forum at Rome was the temple of Castor.

In the two *Homeric Hymns to the Dioscuri*, they are addressed as the Tyndaridae because their mother, Leda, was the wife of Tyndareus. Hymn 17 is short and focuses on their conception and birth:

About Castor and Polydeuces sing, clear-voiced Muse, the Tyndaridae, who are sprung from Olympian Zeus. Beneath the peaks of Mt. Taygetus lady Leda bore them, after she had been stealthily seduced by the dark-clouded son of Cronus.

Hymn 33 depicts the Dioscuri in their important role as patron deities of sailors and seafarers:

O bright-eyed Muses, tell about the sons of Zeus, the Tyndaridae, splendid children of lovely-ankled Leda—Castor, the horse-tamer, and faultless Polydeuces. Leda joined in love with Zeus, the dark-clouded son of Cronus, and she gave birth beneath the summit of the great mountain, Taygetus, to these children, saviors of people on earth and of swift-moving ships, when wintry winds rage over a savage sea. Those on the ship go to the highest part of the stern and call on great Zeus with promises of white lambs. The strong wind and swell of the sea put the ship under water, but suddenly the two brothers appear, darting on tawny wings through the air. At once they calm the blasts of the harsh winds and quell the waves on the expanse of the whitecapped sea. Those who have been freed from pain and toil rejoice, since they have seen these two fair signs of deliverance from distress. (1–17) 10

Hail, Tyndaridae, riders of swift horses! Yet I shall remember you and another song too.

Helen

The daughters of Zeus and Leda were Clytemnestra and Helen. Clytemnestra became the wife of Agamemnon, and we have discussed her part in the Mycenaean saga (Chapter 18). Helen grew up to be the most beautiful of women, and from the many Greek princes (including Theseus and Odysseus) who were her suitors she chose Menelaüs, who became king of Sparta. The rejected suitors swore to respect her choice and help Menelaüs in time of need.

Helen lived for some years at Sparta and bore a daughter, Hermione, to Menelaüs. In time, however, the Trojan prince **Paris** (also called **Alexander**), the son of Priam and Hecuba, visited Sparta while Menelaüs was away in Crete. There he seduced Helen and took her back to Troy with him. To recover her and vindicate the rights of Menelaüs, the Achaean (Mycenaean Greek) expedition, led by Agamemnon, brother of Menelaüs, was raised against Troy.

Another version of Helen's story was invented by the seventh-century poet Stesichorus, who says in his *Palinode*:

That story is not true; you did not go in the well-benched ships, nor did you go to the towers of Troy.

In Stesichorus' version, Helen got only as far as Egypt, where King Proteus detained her until Menelaüs took her back to Sparta after the Trojan War. It was

merely a phantom of Helen that accompanied Paris to Troy, and this was sufficient pretext for the war, which Zeus had determined should occur to reduce the population of the earth.⁴

The Judgment of Paris

The Olympian gods were guests at the wedding feast of Peleus and Thetis. During the feast, **Eris**, goddess of Discord (who was not a guest), threw onto the table an apple inscribed with the words “For the most beautiful.” Hera, Athena, and Aphrodite each claimed it, and Zeus decided that the argument should be settled by Paris.

Now Paris had been exposed as an infant because of a dream that came to his mother Hecuba (the Greek form of her name is Hekabe) before his birth. She dreamed that she had given birth to a firebrand that consumed the whole of Troy, and a soothsayer⁵ foretold that her baby would be the destruction of the city. The infant was exposed on **Mt. Ida** and suckled by a bear. He was found and brought up by a shepherd. Hermes led the three goddesses to him, and each offered the best gift she could provide in return for his favorable decision. Hera promised him royal power and Athena, victory in war, while Aphrodite promised Helen as his wife. He chose Aphrodite, and so the train of events that led to the Trojan War was set in motion, in which Hera and Athena were hostile to the Trojans.

Lucian (*Dialogues of the Gods* 20; Loeb ed., vol. 3, pp. 383–409, *The Judgment of the Goddesses*) offers a satiric version of the judgment of Paris, in tone not unlike Cranach’s painting (p. 471). The sardonic wit of his portrayal illuminates the bitter rivalry, ruthless ambition, and irresponsible passion of the characters, and in so doing they intensify the horror of the tragic events to follow. How bitterly ironic is Paris’ response to Athena: “War and battles serve absolutely no purpose to me. As you see, there is peace throughout Phrygia and Lydia and the entire kingdom of my father.” The satire begins as Zeus gives the golden apple to Hermes with directions to take it and the three goddesses to Paris, who is tending his flocks on Mt. Ida. Hermes is to tell Paris that he has been chosen to make the decision because he is so handsome and knowledgeable in matters of love. Zeus disqualifies himself as judge by saying that he loves all three equally and that if he gives the apple to one he will incur the anger of the others. The goddesses agree to Zeus’ scheme and fly away to Ida with Hermes as their guide. In the course of the journey, each goddess asks for pertinent information about their judge, Paris. As they approach Mt. Ida, Hermes decides that they had better make a landing and walk up to Paris amiably, rather than frighten him by swooping down from the sky. Hermes explains everything to the bewildered Paris and hands him the golden apple with its inscription (20. 7–9):

PARIS: Well then, look at what it says: “Let the beautiful one take me.” Now, lord Hermes, I am a mere mortal and from the country; how am I to become the judge of this marvelous spectacle, too great for a herdsman to handle? To make a decision such as this is a job for a city sophisticate. I could probably judge which is the more beautiful in a contest between two she-goats or two cows, but all these goddesses are equally beautiful. Their beauty surrounds and engulfs me completely. My only regret is that I am not Argus, and so I cannot look at them with eyes all over my body. It seems to me that my best judgment would be to give the apple to all three. For, besides everything else, this one happens to be the sister and wife of Zeus, and these two are his daughters. Doesn’t all this make the decision extremely difficult? 10

HERMES: I don't know. Yet it is impossible to avoid an order given by Zeus.
 PARIS: Just this one request, Hermes. Persuade them—I mean the two who lose—not to hold their defeat against me and to realize that the fault was in my eyes.
 HERMES: They agree that they will not blame you; but now the time has come to go through with the contest.
 PARIS: I'll try. What else can a man do? Still, first I want to know if it will be enough to look at them as they are, or will it be necessary for them to undress for a proper examination?
 HERMES: This would be up to you as the judge. Conduct the proceedings as you desire.
 PARIS: As I desire; I'd like to see them naked.
 HERMES: You goddesses there, undress! And you, Paris, look them over. I have already turned my back. (7–9)

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The goddesses proceed to undress, and Paris is overwhelmed (11–16).



Audio

PARIS: O Zeus, god of marvels! What a sight, what beauty, what ecstasy! The virgin Athena is such a vision! How regal and august is the radiance of Hera, truly a wife worthy of Zeus! The gaze of Aphrodite is so sweet and lovely, and she gave me such a seductive smile. Already this rapture is too much, but if it is all right with you, I'd like to see each one separately, since at this moment I am overwhelmed.
 APHRODITE: Let's do what he wants.
 PARIS: Then the two of you go away, but, Hera, you stay here.
 HERA: Here I stay, and after you have looked me over carefully, the time will be right for you to think about whether other considerations are beautiful too—I mean, the gifts that you will get in return for your vote for me. Paris, if you judge me to be the beautiful one, you will be master of all Asia.
 PARIS: My vote is not determined by gifts: go on now. Athena, you step forward. (11)
 ATHENA: I am right beside you, and if you judge me the beautiful one, Paris, you will never leave a battle in defeat but always victorious. I shall turn you into a warrior and a conquering hero.
 PARIS: War and battles serve absolutely no purpose for me. As you see, there is peace throughout Phrygia and Lydia and the entire kingdom of my father. But cheer up! You will not be at a disadvantage, even if my judgment is not to be made on the basis of gifts. Get dressed now and put on your helmet, for I have seen enough. It's time for Aphrodite to step forward. (12)
 APHRODITE: No rush! Here I am, right beside you. Look at every detail scrupulously. Take your time over every inch of my body, and as you examine me, my beautiful lad, listen to what I have to say. I noticed the moment I saw you how young and handsome you are—I doubt if there is any other fellow in the whole of Troy who is better looking. I congratulate you on your beauty, but it pains me that you do not leave these stony crags for a life in the city. Instead, you are letting your beauty go to waste amidst this isolation. What fun do you get out of these mountains? What good is your beauty to the cows? By now you should be married, not to some country bumpkin like the women from Mt. Ida but to someone from Greece—from Argos or Corinth—or to a Spartan like Helen, young and beautiful as I am and, above all, amorous. If she only got a

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The Judgment of Paris, by Lucas Cranach the Elder (1472–1553); oil on panel, ca. 1528, 401/8 × 28 in. This painting wittily exploits the incongruities of a tale where great goddesses appear naked before a shepherd. Paris is a corpulent Renaissance knight in armor and foppish hat, while an aged Hermes, with stern demeanor, sets off the sensuality of the goddesses. Aphrodite looks fully at the viewer, while Athena looks directly and points at Paris. In the background the towers and spires of Troy can be seen. Cupid draws his bow above, and to the left the horse seems to add his own view of the contest. The horse was omitted in Romare Bearden's *Prologue to Troy* No. 2, which is not included in this edition of *Classical Mythology*. Bearden "transposed Cranach to a black circumstance" (i.e., Paris and the divine figures are black), and he added that "my Paris doesn't need a stud horse in the background." (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

look at you, I know very well that she would leave everything behind, succumb to you completely, follow you home in surrender to live with you as your wife. Of course, you have heard at least something about her? (13)

PARIS: Not a thing, Aphrodite, but it would be my pleasure to hear you tell me everything about her.

APHRODITE: She is actually the daughter of beautiful Leda, whom Zeus seduced after flying down to her in the form of a swan.

PARIS: What does she look like?

APHRODITE: As fair as you would expect the daughter of a swan to be, and soft and delicate, since she was hatched from an eggshell, but yet very athletic too—so sought-after, in fact, that even a war has already been waged over her, because Theseus carried her off when she was still quite young. Furthermore, when she reached the peak of her present perfection, all the best of the Achaeans gathered to seek her hand in marriage. Menelaüs, of the family of Pelops, was the one chosen. If you'd like, I'll arrange her marriage to you.



Closer Look

The Judgment of Paris. Mosaic from Antioch, early second century A.D.; $73 \frac{1}{4} \times 73 \frac{1}{4}$ in. This mosaic was the central panel of an elaborate mosaic floor in a dining room of the Atrium House in Antioch. The three goddesses—Hera enthroned in the center, Athena to the viewer's left, and Aphrodite to the right—appear on a rocky hill, each holding a long scepter. On the left and below, Paris, in Phrygian dress, turns to talk with Hermes. He is guarding a mixed flock of oxen, sheep, and goats, one each of which is shown, the goat drinking from a pool of water. In the center are a tree and a column, on top of which is a golden vase. On the left Psyche (identified by her butterfly wings) stands on a rock, and matching her on the right a winged Cupid stands on a column, anticipating the victory of Aphrodite in the contest. Framing the panel is an elaborate vine, populated with birds, reptiles, and insects, with masks of a man and a woman. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

PARIS: What are you saying? Me with a married woman?

APHRODITE: You are young and naïve, but I know how this kind of thing must be managed. 50

PARIS: How? I want to know too. (14)

APHRODITE: You will take a trip, ostensibly a tour of Greece, and when you come to Sparta, Helen will see you. From then on, it will be up to me to manage how she will fall in love and follow you home.

PARIS: This is the very thing that seems so incredible to me, that she would want to leave her husband and sail away with a foreigner she doesn't know.

APHRODITE: Don't fret about it, for I have two beautiful children, Desire (*Himeros*) and Love (*Eros*). I shall give them to you as guides for your journey. Love will insinuate himself completely into her very being and compel the woman to love you. Desire will make you desirable and irresistible by suffusing you with the very essence of his being. I'll be there myself, too, and I'll ask the Graces to accompany me. In this way, all of us together will persuade her to submit. 60

PARIS: It is not in the least clear to me how this will all turn out, Aphrodite. But I am already in love with Helen. I seem to see her now—I'm sailing straight for Greece—I'm visiting Sparta—I'm returning home holding the woman in my arms! I am very upset that I am not doing all this right now. (15)

APHRODITE: Hold on, Paris! Don't fall in love until you have rewarded me with your decision—me, the one who is fixing the marriage and giving away the bride. It would be only fitting that I, your helper, be the winner of the prize, and that we celebrate at the same time both your marriage and my victory. For it is up to you. You can buy everything—love, beauty, marriage—the cost is this apple. 70

PARIS: I am afraid that you will forget about me after my decision.

APHRODITE: And so you want me to swear an oath?

PARIS: Not at all, only promise me again.

APHRODITE: I promise to give you Helen as your wife and that she herself will follow and come with you to your family in Troy. I shall be at your side myself, and I shall help accomplish everything.

PARIS: And you will bring Love, Desire, and the Graces? 80

APHRODITE: Never fear, I shall even bring along Passionate Longing and Hymen, the god of Marriage.

HERMES: For these promises, then, I award you the apple. Take it. (16)

Homer never mentions this story; according to him (*Iliad* 24. 25–30), Paris once insulted Hera and Athena when they visited him but praised Aphrodite, who gave him the power to attract women irresistibly. This simpler version is certainly older than the more famous literary account of the judgment, but it is the latter that has dominated the tradition and fascinated an endless line of poets and artists.

Troy and Its Leaders

Dardanus

Electra, daughter of Atlas, had two sons by Zeus, Iasion and Dardanus. On the death of Iasion in Samothrace, Dardanus sailed to the Troad, where **Teucer**, son of the river-god Scamander, was king. There Dardanus married the king's daughter and built a city called by his name. On the death of Teucer, the land was called **Dardania** and its inhabitants (as in Homer) **Dardani**. From Dardanus was descended the Trojan royal house.

Laomedon

Apollo and Poseidon (disguised as mortals) built the walls of Troy for its king Laomedon, who then cheated them of their pay.⁶ In punishment, Apollo sent a

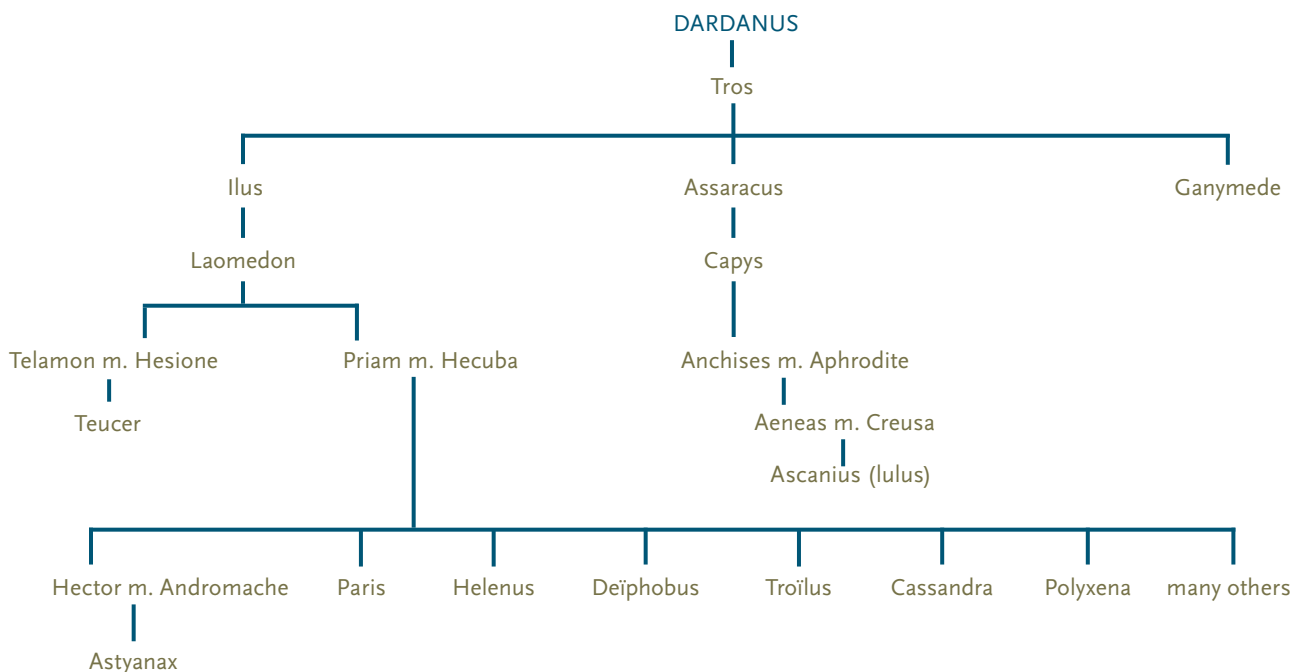


Figure 19.1 The Royal House of Troy

plague and Poseidon a sea monster to harass the Trojans. The oracles advised that the only way to get rid of the monster was to expose Laomedon's daughter **Hesione** and let it devour her. When Heracles came to Troy (see p. 561), he agreed to kill the monster and save Hesione in return for Laomedon's immortal horses, which were the gift of Zeus.⁷ Once again Laomedon cheated his benefactor; Heracles therefore returned with an army, captured Troy, and gave Hesione as wife to his companion, **Telamon**, by whom she became the mother of Teucer. Heracles killed Laomedon but spared his young son Podarces, who became king of the ruined city, changing his name to Priam.

Priam and Hecuba

King Priam was father of fifty sons and twelve (or fifty) daughters, of whom nineteen were children of his second wife, Hecuba (Arisba, his first wife, is not significant in the legend). In the *Iliad*, Hecuba appears as a tragic figure whose sons and husband are doomed; her most famous legend takes place after the fall of Troy (p. 507).

Paris (Alexander)

The most important sons of Priam and Hecuba were Paris and Hector. While Paris was a shepherd on Mt. Ida, he fell in love with a nymph, **Oenone**, who had the gift of healing. He left her for Helen. Years later, when he was wounded

by Philoctetes, she refused to heal him, but when he died, she killed herself in remorse. As a young man, Paris had returned to the royal palace and had been recognized by Priam as his son. As we have seen, Paris' actions led to the Trojan War, in which he appears as a brave warrior, though uxorious. He was the favorite of Aphrodite, who saved him from being killed in combat by Menelaüs. His vanity and sensuality contrasted with the dignity and courage of Hector. Paris shot the arrow that fatally wounded Achilles.

Hector, Andromache, and Astyanax

Hector, brother of Paris, was the champion of the Trojans, brave and honorable. As a warrior he was excelled only by Achilles, by whom he was killed in single combat. As long as Achilles took no part in the fighting, Hector carried all before him. When he was killed, the Trojans knew they were doomed. His wife was Andromache, daughter of Eëtion (an ally of the Trojans killed by Achilles), and their child was Astyanax. In the *Iliad*, Homer draws unforgettable portraits of Paris and Helen and of Hector and Andromache, as he juxtaposes their characters and their relationships in moving scenes of universal power.

Helenus, Deïphobus, and Troilus

Priam's son Helenus had the gift of prophecy, for when he was a child serpents had licked his ears. In the last year of the war, the prophet Calchas advised the Greeks to capture him, since he alone could tell what must be done to end the war. He was caught by Odysseus and honorably treated, so that he alone of Priam's sons survived the war. He eventually married Andromache and became a ruler in Epirus. As a prophet, he appears for the last time in the *Aeneid*, where he foretells the course of Aeneas' future wanderings (p. 688).

Of Priam's many other sons, Deïphobus married Helen after the death of Paris; his ghost spoke with Aeneas in the Underworld; and Troilus, who was killed by Achilles, became more significant in later times.⁸

Cassandra and Polyxena

Cassandra and Polyxena are Priam's most important daughters. Cassandra had been loved by Apollo, who gave her the gift of prophecy. When she rejected him, he added to the gift the fate that she should never be believed. Thus she foretold the fall of Troy and warned the Trojans against the Trojan horse all in vain. Her fate in the sack of Troy is described later in this chapter; as we have seen, she died in Mycenae, murdered by Clytemnestra.

Polyxena, as we describe later in this chapter, was sacrificed on the tomb of Achilles as his share of the spoils after the sack of Troy.

Aeneas

Of the Trojan leaders outside Priam's immediate family, the most prominent is Aeneas, who belonged to another branch of the royal family. Although he was the son of **Anchises** and **Aphrodite**, he was not the equal of Priam in prestige or

of Hector as a warrior. In the *Iliad*, he fights in single combat with Achilles and is saved from death by Poseidon, who transports him miraculously from the fight. Poseidon prophesies that now that Zeus has withdrawn his favor from Priam's family, Aeneas and his descendants will be the future rulers of Troy. We consider his later prominence, as depicted by Vergil, in Chapter 26.

Antenor

Antenor, brother of Hecuba, was conspicuous among those who did not want the war, and he advised returning Helen to the Greeks. When the Greeks first landed, he saved their ambassadors from being treacherously killed by the Trojans. In the last year of the war, he protested the breaking of a truce by the Trojans and still proposed the voluntary return of Helen. The Greeks spared him at the sack, and he and his wife, Theano, the priestess of Athena, were allowed to sail away. They reached Italy, where they founded the city of Patavium (Padua).

Glaucus

Of the allies of Troy, the most prominent in the *Iliad* were the Lycians, led by Glaucus and Sarpedon. When Glaucus and the Greek hero Diomedes were about to fight, they discovered that they were hereditary guest-friends (i.e., their ancestors had entertained one another and exchanged gifts). They exchanged armor instead of fighting and parted amicably. Since Glaucus' armor was made of gold and that of Diomedes of bronze, Diomedes had the better of the exchange, as Homer says (*Iliad* 6. 234–236):

Zeus took away Glaucus' wits, for he exchanged golden armor with Diomedes for bronze, armor that was worth a hundred oxen for armor worth only nine.

Glaucus eventually was killed by Ajax (son of Telamon) in the fight over the corpse of Achilles.

Sarpedon

Sarpedon was the son of Zeus and the Lycian princess Laodamia, daughter of Bellerophon. Zeus foresaw Sarpedon's death but could not change his destiny (*moira*) without upsetting the established order. He therefore had to be content with raining drops of blood on the earth to honor his son before the catastrophe and saving his body after it. Here is Homer's description of the scene (*Iliad* 16. 676–683) after Sarpedon has been killed by Patroclus and Zeus has instructed Apollo to save his body:

Thus [Zeus] spoke, and Apollo did not disobey his father. He went down from the peaks of Ida into the terrible din of battle and straightway lifted godlike Sarpedon out of the way of the missiles and carried him far off. He washed him in the flowing waters of the river and anointed him with ambrosia and clothed him with immortal garments. And he sent him to be carried by two swift escorts, the twins Sleep and Death, who quickly set him down in the fertile land of broad Lycia.

After Hector, Sarpedon is the most noble of the heroes on the Trojan side. In Book 12 of the *Iliad*, when the Trojans are attacking the wall of the Greek camp, he addresses Glaucus in words expressing heroic *arete* (excellence) and nobility as memorable as those of Achilles in Book 9 (translated on p. 492). Unlike Achilles, he speaks as the leader of a community (*Iliad* 12. 310–328):

Glaucus, why are we specially honored in Lycia with seats of honor, with meat and more cups of wine, and all people look upon us like gods, and we have been allotted a great domain beside the banks of the Xanthus, fine for the planting of vineyards and for grain-bearing tillage? Therefore now must we stand in the front rank of the Lycians and face the raging battle, so that one of the well-armored Lycians may say: “Indeed not without glory do our kings rule over Lycia and eat the fat lambs and drink choice honey-sweet wine. Noble also is their strength, since they fight among the leaders of the Lycians.” My friend, if we were to avoid this war and were to live out our lives ever ageless and deathless, then neither would I myself fight among the leaders, nor would I station you in the battle that destroys men. 10 Now, as it is, let us go, for ten thousand death-bringing fates are close upon us.

Rhesus

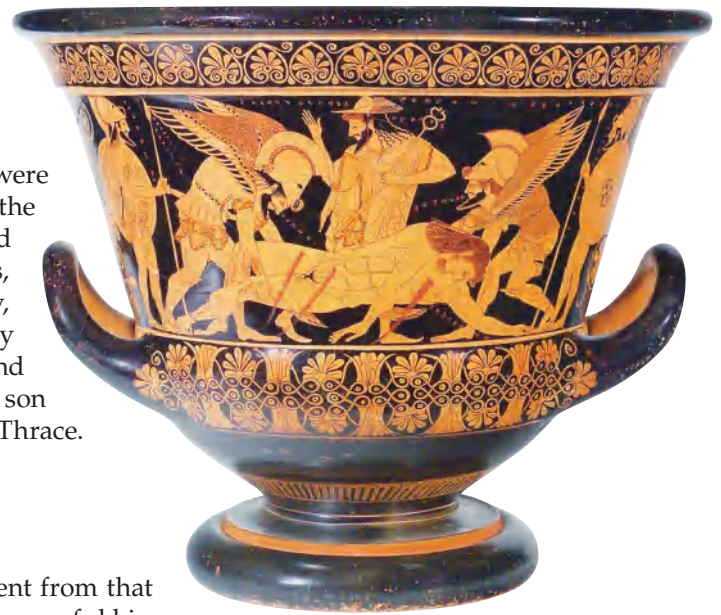
Other allied contingents who appeared at Troy were those of the Amazons and the Ethiopians, and the Thracians led by Rhesus. Their arrival coincided with a night patrol by Diomedes and Odysseus, during which they caught and killed a Trojan spy, **Dolon**, who first told them of the Thracians. They went on to kill Rhesus and twelve of his men and to capture his white horses. Rhesus, who was a son of one of the Muses, was worshiped as a hero in Thrace.

The Achaean Leaders

The organization of the Greek army was different from that of the Trojans, for Troy was a great city led by a powerful king and helped in war by independent allies. We have seen that Helen’s suitors had sworn to help Menelaüs if he called on them, and they assembled for war under the leadership of Agamemnon, king of Mycenae. While Agamemnon’s position as leader was unquestioned, each of the Greek princes led his contingent independently and could at any time withdraw, as Achilles did.

Agamemnon

Agamemnon was the “lord of men,” greatest in prestige among the Greeks, although neither the greatest warrior nor the wisest in council. His stature is shown in the scene in Book 3 of the *Iliad* when Helen names the Greek warrior whom Priam points out to her from their viewpoint on the wall (hence the scene is known as the “viewing from the wall,” or *teichoskopia*). Priam begins (*Iliad* 3. 166–190):



The Death of Sarpedon. Athenian red-figure krater by Euphronios, ca. 510 B.C.; height 18 in. The winged gods, Sleep (Hypnos, *left*) and Death (Thanatos, *right*), carry the body from the battlefield under the guidance of Hermes as two Greek warriors look on. The gods wear armor (note the chain mail of Thanatos), but the corpse of Sarpedon has been stripped. The vase is one of the masterpieces of Athenian vase painting. (*Soprintendenza per i Beni Archeologici dell'Etruria Meridionale*)



Diomedes and Odysseus
Stealing the Palladium from
Troy. Detail from an Attic
red-figure amphora by the
Tyszkiewicz painter, early fifth
century B.C. Diomedes holds
the Palladium in his right
hand. (Medelhavsmuseet,
Stockholm, photographer Ove
Kaneberg. Inv. nr. MM 1963:1)

after the sack of Troy, see page 518, and for Euripides' versions of his part in the stories of Orestes and Neoptolemus, see pages 445–447.

Diomedes

Diomedes, king of Argos, was a much greater warrior than Menelaüs. He was the son of Tydeus and second only to Agamemnon in power and prestige. He was also a wise counselor. He was a favorite of Athena and with her help could oppose even the gods in battle. He wounded both Ares and Aphrodite. He was especially associated with Odysseus, with whom he fetched Achilles from Scyros and later Philoctetes from Lemnos. Odysseus was also his companion in the night patrol where Dolon and Rhesus were killed and in the theft of the Palladium from Troy. This **Palladium** (the statue of Pallas, which Athena had made and Zeus cast down from heaven into Troy) was worshiped and looked upon as a talisman for the city's survival. When Odysseus and Diomedes stole it, Troy was doomed. Diomedes' meeting with Glaucus has already been described; his adventures after the war are discussed on p. 518.

"Tell me the name of this mighty man, whoever he is of the Greeks, a man valiant and great. . . ."

Then Helen answered in words, goddess-like among women. . . . "This is the son of Atreus, Agamemnon, ruler of a broad kingdom, both a noble king and a strong warrior. He was my husband's brother." Thus she spoke, and the old man was filled with wonder and said: "O happy son of Atreus, favored by Destiny, blest by fortune, many sons of the Achaeans are your subjects. Long ago I went to Phrygia rich in vineyards, and there I saw great numbers of Phrygian warriors on their swift horses. . . . But not even they were as great as are the quick-eyed Achaeans."

10

In Book 11 (36–40), the terror inspired by Agamemnon as a warrior is shown in the devices on his shield and shield-strap, "The grim-looking Gorgon with her terrifying gaze, and around the shield Terror and Fear. And on the strap coiled a dark serpent, and it had three heads turning all ways, growing from one neck." Yet great warrior as Agamemnon was, he was a lesser hero than Achilles.

Menelaüs

We have seen how Menelaüs, king of Sparta, and his wife Helen were involved in the origin of the war. In the war itself, he fought Paris in single combat. Aphrodite saved Paris just as Menelaüs was on the point of killing him. For the adventures of Menelaüs

Nestor

Nestor, king of Pylos and a son of Neleus, was the oldest and wisest of the Greek leaders. Like Priam, he had become king after Heracles sacked his city. In the sack, Neleus and all his sons except Nestor were killed. At Troy, Nestor was a respected counselor, and his speeches, full of reminiscences, contrast with the impetuosity of the younger princes. He himself survived the war, although his son Antilochus was killed by Memnon. There is no tradition of his death.

Ajax the Greater of Salamis, the Son of Telamon

Ajax, son of Telamon, was second only to Achilles as a warrior.⁹ He is called the Great (or Greater) to distinguish him from Ajax the Less (or Lesser), son of Oïleus. In the fighting before the Greek ships (Books 13–15), he was the most stalwart defender, always courageous and the last to give ground to the enemy. Again he was the Greek champion in the fight over the body of Patroclus in Book 17, providing cover while Menelaüs and Meriones retreated with the body. At the climax of that battle, he prayed to Zeus to dispel the mist of battle and let him die in the clear sunlight, a striking scene in which the sudden appearance of the sun and clear vision seems especially appropriate for this straightforward warrior. In the *teichoskopia*, Priam asks Helen (*Iliad* 3. 226–229):

“Who is this other Achaean warrior, valiant and great, who stands out from the Achaeans with his head and broad shoulders?” [Helen replies] “This is Ajax, of huge size, the bulwark of the Achaeans.”

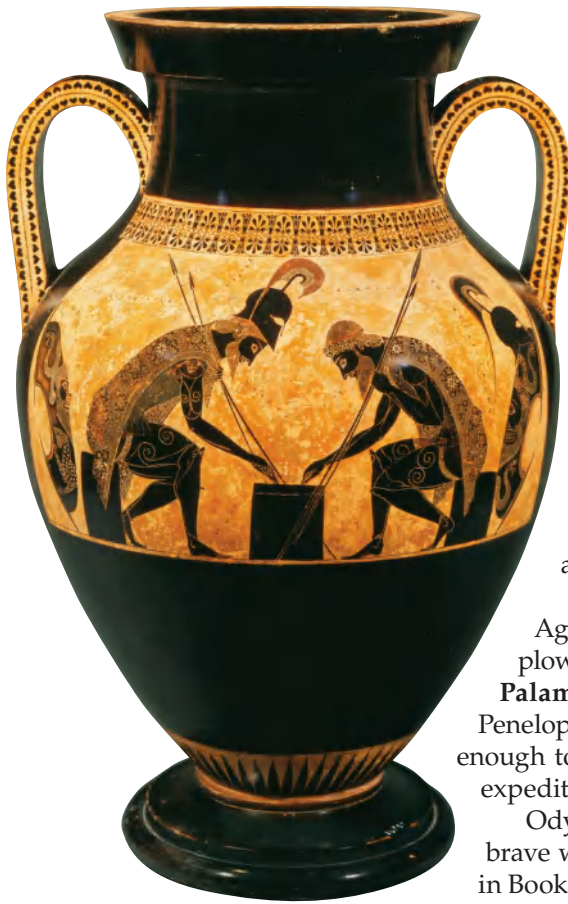
Ajax is both the foil to and the rival of Odysseus. His gruff and laconic speech in the embassy to Achilles (Book 9), which we discuss later, contrasts with the smooth words of the diplomatic Odysseus. In Book 23, they compete in the wrestling match in the funeral games; Ajax’s defeat there foreshadows his far more tragic defeat in the contest with Odysseus for the armor of Achilles, discussed later in this chapter.

Ajax the Less (or Lesser)

Ajax the Less (as Homer calls him), prince of the Locrians and son of Oïleus, is a less attractive character than his namesake. Although he figured prominently in the fighting and was the leader of a large contingent, his sacrilegious violation of Cassandra during the sack of Troy diminished his stature and led to his death on the voyage back to Greece (p. 517).

Idomeneus

Another important fighter with a large contingent was Idomeneus, son of Deucalion and leader of the Cretans. He stood in a different relationship to Agamemnon from most of the other leaders in that he came as a voluntary ally. He had long been a friend of Menelaüs, and Agamemnon showed him great respect. In Book 13 of the *Iliad*, he defends the Greek camp bravely and kills a number of leading Trojan warriors. Good as he was as fighter and counselor at Troy, his most important legend is concerned with his return (p. 518).¹⁰



Achilles and Ajax Playing a Board Game. Attic amphora signed by Exekias as painter and potter, ca. 535 B.C.; height 24 ½ in. There is no literary source for this scene, which appears in over 150 vase paintings, sometimes with the addition of Athena in armor. Achilles (to the viewer's left) and Ajax are partly armed, while their shields are propped up behind them along with Ajax's helmet on the right. Bending over the log that serves as a game-board, they count their points won, the numbers (four for Achilles, three for Ajax) being written out on the painting. The theme of heroes taking a break from battle is further emphasized by the elaborate decoration of their mantles, hardly the dress for warriors going into battle. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)

Odysseus

When Menelaüs and Agamemnon sent heralds throughout Greece and the islands to summon the Greek leaders and their contingents to the war, not all the Greek heroes came willingly; two of the most important, Odysseus and Achilles, attempted to avoid the war by subterfuge.

Odysseus, king of Ithaca, pretended to be mad. When Agamemnon's envoys came, he yoked an ox and an ass and plowed a field, sowing salt in the furrows. One of the envoys, **Palamedes**, took Odysseus' infant son Telemachus from his mother, Penelope, and put him in the path of the plow. Odysseus was sane enough to avoid him; his pretense was uncovered, and he joined the expedition.¹¹

Odysseus was the craftiest and wisest of the Greeks, as well as a brave warrior. He was the best in council, and his powerful speech in Book 2 (284–332) decided the debate in favor of staying before Troy to finish the war. He attacked the unattractive and sardonic **Thersites** for intervening in the debate, when only princes should speak, and for this he was greatly honored by the Greeks. He was the principal speaker in the embassy to Achilles in Book 9, and he undertook the dangerous night mission with Diomedes as well as other missions mentioned earlier. Above all, Odysseus was a skilled speaker, as is brought out in the *teichoskopia* (a viewing from the wall), a designation given to the section of the *Iliad* where Helen identifies for Priam the Greek commanders (*Iliad* 3. 191–224):

Next the old man [Priam] asked about Odysseus. "Come, tell me also about this man, dear child, who he is. He is shorter by a head than Agamemnon, son of Atreus, but I see that he is broader in the shoulders and chest. His arms lie on the fruitful earth, and he like a ram is going up and down the ranks of warriors. I liken him to a thick-fleeced ram which goes through the flocks of white-fleeced sheep." Then Helen, daughter of Zeus, answered: "This is crafty Odysseus, son of Laërtes, who was raised in the land of Ithaca, rocky though it is. He knows all kinds of deceit and clever plans." (191–202)

Then wise Antenor spoke to her and said: "Lady, true indeed are your words. Godlike Odysseus came here once before with Menelaüs, dear to Ares, for news of you. I was their host and welcomed them in my home, and I knew their stature and their wise intelligence. But when they joined in the assembly

of the Trojans, Menelaüs was taller when they stood by his [head and] broad shoulders; yet when they both were seated Odysseus was the more noble. But when they began to weave their speeches and proposals before all, then indeed Menelaüs spoke glibly, a few words in a clear voice, since he was not long-winded or irrelevant, and he was younger also. But whenever wise Odysseus rose to speak, he would stand and look down and fix his eyes on the ground, and he would not gesture with the sceptre before or behind him, but held it stiffly, like some unskilled man. You would say that he was angry and unintelligent too. But when he sent forth the great voice from his chest and the words that were like falling winter snows, then no other mortal could compete with Odysseus. Indeed, then we were not amazed as we looked at the appearance of Odysseus." (203–224) 20

The double portrait of the wise orator and the glib young king vividly puts before us two sides of the heroic ethos, and it prepares us for the complexity of Odysseus' character in the saga of his return from Troy.

Achilles, His Parents, Peleus and Thetis, and His Son, Neoptolemus (Pyrrhus)

The second chieftain who attempted to avoid the war was Achilles, prince of the **Myrmidons** (a tribe of Phthia, in northern Greece on the southern border of Thessaly) and the greatest of the Greek warriors as well as the swiftest and most handsome. He was the son of Peleus and Thetis; Thetis was a sea-goddess, daughter of Nereus, who was avoided by Zeus when the secret was revealed hitherto known only to Prometheus and Themis—that Thetis' son would be greater than his father.¹² Their son Achilles did indeed become greater than his father.

Peleus was the son of Aeacus, king of Aegina and brother of Telamon. For killing his half-brother Phocus, he had to leave Aegina, whereupon he went to Eurytion of Phthia, who purified him and gave him part of his kingdom. Peleus accompanied Eurytion on the Calydonian boar hunt and accidentally killed him with a javelin intended for the boar. He went into exile again and was purified by Acastus, son of Pelias and king of Iolcus.

Now the wife of Acastus, Astydamia (Pindar calls her Hippolyta) fell in love with Peleus, and when he refused her advances, she accused him before her husband of trying to seduce her.¹³ Rather than kill his guest, Acastus took him hunting on Mt. Pelion, where he left him asleep, but not before hiding his sword (a gift from Hephaestus) in a pile of dung. Peleus awoke to find himself surrounded by wild animals and centaurs, who would have killed him had not Chiron protected him and given him back his sword.

When Zeus avoided a union with Thetis, whose son was destined to be greater than his father, she was given to Peleus because of his virtue. The wedding feast was celebrated on Mt. Pelion, and all the gods and goddesses came as guests. As we have seen, with them came Eris (Discord) as an uninvited guest, bringing the apple that eventually led to the judgment of Paris and the Trojan War. Peleus returned to Phthia, where he became the father of Achilles. Thetis soon left Peleus, angry because he interrupted her while she was making Achilles immortal.

Thus Thetis was married to a mortal, Peleus, king of the Phthians. Peleus took part in the Argonauts' expedition and the Calydonian boar hunt, but as

Peleus Wrestles with Thetis.

Red figure kylix by the Peithinos painter, ca. 510 B.C.

Peleus holds on to the body of Thetis, who transforms herself into wild animals, represented here by a lion and three snakes (respectively on the right forearm and feet of Peleus and the left arm of Thetis). The inscriptions name Peleus and Thetis and include a dedication by Peithinos to his lover, Athenodotus. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)



a mere mortal he was hardly a match for Thetis. It was with difficulty that he married her, for she was able to turn herself into various shapes in attempting to escape from him. Although the gods attended their wedding feast, Thetis left Peleus not long after the birth of Achilles. She tried to make Achilles immortal, either by roasting him in the fire by night and anointing him with ambrosia by day¹⁴ or by dipping him in the waters of the Styx. In the latter story, all parts of Achilles' body that had been submerged were invulnerable. Only his heel, by which Thetis held him, remained vulnerable. It was here that he received the fatal arrow wound.

Once Thetis had left Peleus, Achilles was sent to the centaur **Chiron** for his education. From him he learned the art of music and other skills. While Achilles was with Chiron, Thetis learned that Troy could not be taken without Achilles; she also knew that he could live long and die ingloriously or go to Troy and die young and glorious. To circumvent his early death, she tried to prevent his going by disguising him as a girl and taking him to the island of **Scyros**, where he was brought up with the **daughters of Lycomedes**, king of the island. One of them was **Deïdamia**, with whom Achilles fell in love; their child, born after Achilles left Scyros, was Neoptolemus (also called Pyrrhus, which means "redhead"), who took part in the capture of Troy after his father's death. Odysseus and Diomedes exposed Achilles'

disguise at Scyros. They took gifts for the daughters of Lycomedes, among them weapons and armor, in which Achilles alone showed any interest. As the women were looking at the gifts, Odysseus arranged for a trumpet to sound; the women all ran away, thinking it was a battle signal, but Achilles took off his disguise and put on the armor. Here is the description of the scene by the Roman poet Statius (*Achilleid* 1. 852–884), after the gifts have been set out by Diomedes:

The daughters of Lycomedes see the arms and assume that they are a present for their mighty father. But when fierce Achilles saw the shining shield close by, chased with scenes of war and lying next to the spear, he grew violent . . . and Troy filled his heart. . . . When he saw his reflection in the golden shield, he shuddered and blushed. Then observant Odysseus stood close to him and whispered: “Why do you hesitate? We know. You are the pupil of the centaur, Chiron, you are the descendant of [the gods of] sky and sea. The Greek fleet is waiting for you, the Greek army is waiting for you before raising its standards, the walls of Troy itself are ready to fall before you. Hurry, no more delaying!” . . . Already Achilles was beginning to take off his woman’s dress when Agyrtes 10 sounded a loud blast on the trumpet, as he had been ordered to do [by Odysseus]. The girls began to run away, scattering the gifts. . . . Achilles’ clothing of itself fell from his chest, and he quickly seized the shield and short spear and, miraculously, he seemed to be taller by head and shoulders than Odysseus and Diomedes. . . . Stepping like a hero he stood forth.

So Achilles was discovered and joined the expedition. At Troy, he proved to be the mightiest of the champions on either side and a hero of enormous passions.

Phoenix and Patroclus

Two of Achilles’ associates, Phoenix and Patroclus, are important. Phoenix, at the instigation of his mother, lay with his father’s mistress. His father cursed him with childlessness, and Phoenix sought refuge from his father’s wrath with Peleus, who made him the tutor and companion of Achilles both in Phthia and at Troy.

Patroclus was a great warrior. When very young, he had killed a rival in anger over a dice game. Peleus took him in and brought him up to be the companion of Achilles. Achilles and Patroclus become devoted friends and perhaps lovers, and their relationship provides a major theme for the *Iliad*.¹⁵

The Gathering of the Expedition at Aulis

Menelaüs and Agamemnon sent heralds throughout Greece and the islands to summon the Greek leaders and contingents to the war; the expedition gathered at **Aulis** (on the coast of Boeotia, opposite Euboea) numbering nearly twelve hundred ships with their crews and fighting men.¹⁶

The Sacrifice of Iphigenia

There were delays before the fleet could sail; for a long time contrary winds blew, and in despair Agamemnon consulted the prophet Calchas. He knew that Artemis had caused the unfavorable weather because Agamemnon had offended her¹⁷



The Anger of Achilles, by J.-L. David (1748–1825); oil on canvas, 1819, 41½ x 57 ¼ in. Iphigenia has been brought to Aulis on the pretext that she is to be the bride of Achilles. David shows the moment when Agamemnon has revealed his true intention to Achilles, who draws his sword in anger to strike Agamemnon. The anger of the men contrasts with the sadness of Iphigenia, who has learned that she will be sacrificed, and of Clytemnestra, who gazes at Achilles as she puts her hand on her daughter's shoulder. The subject is based on Euripides' tragedy, *Iphigenia at Aulis*. (Kimbell Art Museum, Fort Worth, Texas/Art Resource, NY)

and that she could only be appeased by the sacrifice of Agamemnon's daughter Iphigenia, who therefore was fetched from Mycenae (on the pretext that she was to be married to Achilles) and sacrificed. In another version, Artemis saved her at the last moment, substituted a stag as the victim, and took Iphigenia to the land of the Tauri (the modern Crimea) to be her priestess.¹⁸

Lucretius, the Roman poet (ca. 55 B.C.), tells the story of Iphigenia with bitter pathos to show to what lengths men will go in the name of religion (*De rerum natura* 1. 84–101):

Look how the chosen leaders of the Greeks, the foremost of men, foully defiled the altar of virgin Artemis at Aulis with the blood of Iphigenia. As they placed around her maiden's hair the headband which hung down evenly by her cheeks, she suddenly caught sight of her father standing sadly before the altar and at his side his ministers hiding the knife, while the people shed tears at the sight of her. Dumb with fear she fell to the ground on her knees. At such a moment little help to her in her misery was it that she had been his first child, that she had first bestowed upon the king the name of father. The hands of men brought her trembling to the altar, not that she might perform the customary ritual of marriage to the clear-ringing songs of Hymen, but that at the very time for her wedding she might fall a sad and sinless victim, sinfully butchered by her own

father, all for the happy and auspicious departure of the fleet. Such are the monstrous evils to which religion could lead.

Calchas' Prophecy

Calchas the prophet was an important figure in the Greek expedition, especially in times of doubt or perplexity. At Troy, as we shall see later, he gave the reason for Apollo's anger and advised the return of Chryseïs to her father. At Aulis, he interpreted a famous omen. A snake was seen to climb up a tree and devour eight chicks from a nest high in its branches; it then ate the mother and was itself turned into stone by Zeus. Calchas correctly interpreted this to mean that the Greeks would fight unsuccessfully at Troy for nine years before capturing the city in the tenth.¹⁹

The Arrival at Troy

Philoctetes

The expedition finally sailed from Aulis but did not go straight to Troy. On the way, the Greeks were guided by Philoctetes, son of Poeas, to the island of Chryse to sacrifice to its goddess. There Philoctetes was bitten in the foot by a snake; and as the fleet sailed on, the stench from his wound became so noisome that the Greeks abandoned him on the island of Lemnos, where he remained alone and in agony for nearly ten years. Now Philoctetes' father, Poeas, had lit the funeral pyre of Heracles and had in return been given Heracles' bow and arrows, which Philoctetes later inherited. In the last year of the war, the Greeks captured Priam's son Hele-nus, who prophesied that only with the aid of Heracles' bow and arrows could Troy be captured. Accordingly, Odysseus and Diomedes fetched Philoctetes from Lemnos. The sons of Asclepius, Podalirius and Machaon, healed his wound, and with the arrows he shot Paris, thus removing the most formidable of the surviving Trojan champions.²⁰

Achilles Heals Telephus

On the way to Troy, the Greeks landed in Mysia, a district of Asia Minor. In the battle against the Mysians, Achilles wounded the Mysian Telephus, a son of Heracles. When

Philoctetes on Lemnos. Red-figure lekythos, ca. 430 B.C. A lekythos was a type of vase for storing oil or perfume, used primarily in religious contexts, including funerals. Many vases of this type have been found in tombs, and the subject matter is often somber in tone. Illustrations of this tale depict either Philoctetes at the depth of his despair on the island of Lemnos or the expedition of the Greeks to Lemnos to fetch the great hero. Philoctetes sits alone on his deserted isle, his left foot bandaged, resting on a rock, with the unerring bow of Heracles by his side. (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)



the wound would not heal, Telephus despairingly asked the Delphic oracle for advice. Learning that “he that wounded shall heal,” he went to the Greek army disguised as a beggar and asked Achilles to cure his wound. Achilles said he could not, for he was not a doctor, but Odysseus pointed out that it was Achilles’ spear that had caused the wound. Scrapings from it were applied, and Telephus was healed. The myth of Telephus was prominent in the Great Altar at Pergamum (see p. 85).

Protesilaüs and Laodamia

When the Greeks reached Troy, the first to leap ashore was Protesilaüs, who was immediately killed by Hector. His wife, Laodamia, could not be comforted in her grief. Pitying her, Hermes brought back her husband from Hades for a few hours, and when he was taken away again, she killed herself. This story, with its themes of return from the dead and a wife’s love, was developed in Euripides’ tragedy *Protesilaus*, now mostly lost. Another person to die in the first skirmish was a Trojan, **Cycnus**, son of Poseidon, who was turned into a swan. The Greeks successfully established a beachhead, made a permanent camp with their ships drawn up on shore, and settled down to besiege Troy.

The *Iliad*

While the events of the first nine years of the war are obscure (since the epic poems in which they were described survive only in prose summaries), those of the tenth are in part brilliantly illuminated by the *Iliad*. The poem, however, deals only with events from the outbreak of the quarrel between Achilles and Agamemnon to the ransoming and burial of Hector.

Nine years were spent in a fruitless siege of Troy, varied only by abortive diplomatic exchanges and raids against cities allied with Troy. The division of the spoil from these cities led to the quarrel between Agamemnon and Achilles. Agamemnon was given in his share **Chryseïs**, daughter of **Chryses**, priest of Apollo—but (as we shall see) he had to send her back. Therefore he took **Briseïs**, who had been given to Achilles and whom Achilles had come to love greatly. The wrath of Achilles, the principal theme of the *Iliad*, is characterized in the poem’s opening lines (1. 1–7):

The wrath of Achilles, Peleus’ son, sing, O goddess, a ruinous wrath, which put countless woes upon the Achaeans and hurled many mighty souls of heroes to Hades, and made them a feast for dogs and a banquet for birds, and the will of Zeus was being accomplished, from the time when first Agamemnon and Achilles stood opposed in strife.

The passionate theme of “wrath,” the very word with which the poem begins, determines the intensity of emotion and the scope and form of its action. In verses of visual and auditory clarity as deceptively simple as they are profound, the story unfolds through scenes of great dramatic power. With Chryseïs in his possession, Agamemnon refused to allow Chryses to ransom his daughter, and Chryses therefore prayed to Apollo to punish the Greeks. Apollo’s answer to the prayer is described in these vivid lines (*Iliad* 1. 43–52):

So Chryses prayed, and Phoebus Apollo heard him. Angry at heart, he strode down from the peaks of Olympus, having his bow slung from his shoulder and his hollow quiver. The arrows clashed loudly upon his shoulders as he strode in his anger, and like night did he go. Then he sat apart from the ships and shot an arrow; terrible was the twang of his silver bow. First he shot the mules and the swift dogs, and next he shot his sharp arrow at the men. Constantly were the funeral pyres burning in great numbers.

This is the first appearance of a god in the *Iliad*, and it shows how the gods are participants in the saga of Troy, with Apollo constantly favoring the Trojans. Calchas advised that the evil could be ended only by the return, without ransom, of Chryseïs. Accordingly, she was sent back, but this left Agamemnon without his share of the spoils, a humiliating situation for the greatest of the Greek kings. He therefore took Briseïs from Achilles, and Achilles repaid the dishonor by withdrawing his contingent, the Myrmidons, from the war.

Achilles is the embodiment of heroic *arete* (excellence). Important in the concept of *arete* is one's standing in the eyes of others, which is gained not only by words and deeds but also by gifts and spoils relative to those of others. Therefore, Achilles' honor was slighted when Agamemnon took away Briseïs, and he had good cause to withdraw from the fighting, even though the Greeks suffered terribly as a result. Homer describes the mighty quarrel, during the course of which Athena restrains Achilles from attacking Agamemnon. Homer describes the prophecy of Achilles as he withdraws from the war (1. 234–246):²¹

"By this sceptre, which will never grow leaves or roots, since it was cut in the mountains . . . and now the sons of the Achaeans bear it in their hands when they administer justice, for they defend Justice in the name of Zeus—and this will be a great oath: In time all the sons of the Achaeans will long for Achilles. Then you [Agamemnon] will not be able to do anything, grieved though you be, while many men fall in death before Hector, slayer of men. And you will tear your heart, angry that you did not honor the best of the Achaeans." So spoke the son of Peleus, and he cast the golden-studded sceptre upon the ground, and down he sat.

Angry, hurt, and resentful, Achilles finds comfort and support from his mother, Thetis. Theirs is a sad and touching relationship, tragic in the knowledge that Achilles has chosen to come to Troy to die young and gloriously rather than stay at home to live a long but mundane existence. Thetis agrees to go to Zeus for help, and she obtains from the supreme god an oath that he will honor her son, whom Agamemnon has dishonored, and grant success to the Trojans in his absence, so that the Greeks will come to regret Agamemnon's actions and increase the glory of Achilles.

At the end of Book 1, it is difficult not to condemn Agamemnon as a guilty, arrogant sinner, first against Apollo and his priest and then against Achilles. Achilles' tragic withdrawal, like Apollo's arrows, will cause the deaths of countless of his Greek companions, and he will be condemned for his selfish, cruel, and pitiless behavior. Yet the wrath of Apollo, until properly appeased, has been just as devastating, heartless, and indiscriminate, causing innumerable deaths, in this case, too, because of the arrogance of Agamemnon. Homer juxtaposes the wrath of Achilles and that of Apollo at the beginning of his epic. Are we to

judge the actions of the god and those of the mortal demigod by two different standards?

In Book 3, a truce is agreed upon to allow Menelaüs and Paris to fight in individual combat in order to decide the issues and the fate of Helen. In the duel, Menelaüs gets the better of Paris. He takes hold of Paris by the helmet and swings him around so that he is choked by the neck-strap. When Aphrodite notices that Paris is lost, she quickly snatches up her favorite with the ease of a goddess and transports him to his fragrant bedchamber. She goes to summon Helen, who has already witnessed the humiliation of her husband from a high tower of Troy. Although Aphrodite is disguised as an old woman, Helen recognizes the beautiful breasts and flashing eyes of her mirror image, and with this recognition of herself she rebels.

As the scene proceeds, through the literal depiction of the goddess Aphrodite, the inner soul (the psyche) of Helen is laid bare. Helen wonders where in the world beauty and passion—Aphrodite—will lead her next, and in indignation she demands that the goddess abandon Olympus and go herself to Paris until he makes her his wife or his slave. Helen is too ashamed before the eyes of the Trojan women to return to his bed. At this, Aphrodite becomes enraged and threatens to turn against Helen. Helen submissively returns to her bedchamber and to Paris, whom Aphrodite has restored from a bedraggled loser into a beautiful dandy. Yet a disillusioned Helen greets her beloved with these demeaning words (3. 428–436):

“You have come out of battle? You ought to have died there, beaten by a stronger man, who was my former husband. To be sure you boasted before that you were mightier than warlike Menelaüs in the might of your hands and your sword. So then go now and challenge warlike Menelaüs again to face you in battle. No, I bid you hold on and do not fight in combat against blond Menelaüs in your rashness, lest somehow you will quickly be subdued by his spear.”

Paris responds with characteristic nonchalance, and Aphrodite is victorious once again (3. 438–447):

“My wife, do not rebuke me with harsh words; now Menelaüs has won with the help of Athena. At another time I will beat him, for the gods are on our side too. Come on now, let us go to bed and make love. Never at any time has desire so clouded my senses, not even when we first consummated our love on the island of Cranaë, after I had carried you out of lovely Sparta and we sailed away. This is how I love you now and how sweet desire takes hold of me.” He spoke, and led her to bed, and his wife followed along.

In Book 6, Hector, the valiant brother of Paris, seeks out his wife, Andromache, to bid her farewell before returning to the battlefield. On his way he looks in on Paris, who is still dallying with Helen in their home. After his defeat by Menelaüs and his lovemaking with Helen, Paris is sullenly polishing his armor. Hector has presumably interrupted another of their quarrels. Paris tells his brother how Helen has just now been urging him to go out to battle, and he agrees with them both that it is time for him to return. Helen speaks to Hector in words fraught with misery and self-reproach (6. 344–358):

“My brother-in-law, how I wish that I—cold, evil-scheming bitch that I am—had died on the day when first I was born before all this had happened—that a terrible blast of wind had hurled me into the side of a mountain or into a wave of the resounding sea to be swept away. But since the gods have so ordained these evils, I wish that I were the wife of a better man, who felt a sense of guilt and shame before the eyes of society. But his character is not rooted in such values and he will never change, and so I think that he will reap the rewards. Now come here and sit down in this chair, brother-in-law, since the battle toil has crushed you the most, all on account of me, a bitch, and retribution for Paris’ guilt. Upon us both has Zeus imposed an evil fate, so that we might become for future generations the subjects for poetic songs.” 10

Hector tells Helen that he must be on his way. He finds that his wife, their son Astyanax, and the boy’s nurse are not at home; they have been anxiously watching from the battlements in concern for his fate. In the sad farewell between husband and wife, Andromache implores Hector not to go to battle and leave her a widow and their child an orphan. Achilles has already killed her father and seven brothers; he captured their mother, and although he accepted a ransom for her return, she has died too. So Hector is father, mother, and brother to her, as well as dear husband. Hector responds with loving conviction (6. 441–484):

“To be sure, all these things are of deep concern to me too, but I should feel terrible shame before the Trojan women with their long robes if like a coward I were to shrink from battle. Nor would my spirit allow me to, since I have learned to be brave always and to fight amidst the first of the Trojans, winning great glory for myself and for my father. For I know this well in my heart and in my soul. The day will come when Troy will be destroyed and Priam and the people of Priam of the fine ashen spear. The suffering that will follow for the Trojans—for Hecuba herself and king Priam and my many brave brothers who will fall in the dust under the hands of their enemies—is not so much a grief for me as is the pain that you will endure when one of the bronze-clad Achaeans leads you away weeping and takes from you the day of your liberty. In Greece at another’s bidding you will work the loom and draw water from a spring in Laconia or Thessaly, much against your will, but heavy necessity will lie upon you. Then someone, seeing you in tears, will say, ‘This is the wife of Hector, who was by far the best fighter when the horse-taming Trojans did battle for Ilium.’ Thus at some time will someone speak, and your grief will be awakened anew because you are without such a husband to ward off the day of your slavery. But may I die with the earth heaped up over my grave before I hear your cries of anguish as you are dragged away a captive.” (6. 441–465) 10 20

Thus radiant Hector spoke and reached out for his son, but the child clung to the bosom of the fair-girdled nurse, screaming in dismay at the sight of his father, startled as he saw the bronze crest of his helmet and the horsehair plume nodding dreadful from its peak. His dear father laughed aloud, and his lady mother, and immediately Hector took the helmet from his head and placed it all-shining on the ground. Then he kissed his dear son and fondled him in his arms and spoke in prayer to Zeus and the other gods: (6. 466–475)



Audio

“Zeus and you other gods, grant that this son of mine become outstanding among the Trojans, just as I am, excellent in his might and a strong ruler over Ilium. Some day let someone say that this boy has turned out to be far better than his father, as he comes out of the battle, and when he has killed his enemy may he bring home the gory spoils and may his mother rejoice in her heart.” Thus speaking he placed his son in the hands of his dear wife. She took him to her fragrant bosom, laughing amidst her tears. (6. 476–484)



Hector and Andromache, by Giorgio de Chirico (1888–1978); oil on canvas, 1917, 35 1/2 × 23 1/2 in. Husband and wife, mannequins backed by receding frames, part at the Scaean Gate in an austere, stagelike setting with receding perspective. They are sheathed in geometrically shaped metallic plates, and the baby Astyanax is reduced to a steel wedge with a black disk for his head. De Chirico's images of the intersection of war and the family are a disturbing interpretation of Homer's moving scene. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look